Resolution No. 7109

Urgent Need for Seismic Retrofitting of High-Risk School Buildings

The Portland Public School Board finds the following:

A. Most Portland Public Schools (PPS) facilities were constructed decades ago (with the majority built over 75 years ago) and are in need of critical repairs, improvements and upgrades to essential building systems, including roofs, plumbing, electrical, and HVAC heating and cooling systems. Most Portland schools were built well before modern health and safety standards, and continued improvements, replacements, and upgrades are needed to remove and remediate hazardous substances, systems and infrastructure.

B. In addition, most PPS schools were built before modern seismic building codes, leaving many school buildings structurally vulnerable to serious damage or collapse in a major earthquake.

C. The May 2025 Bond includes an $190 million allocation Physical Facility Improvements intended to address deferred maintenance, ongoing capital renewal and priority scope improvements.

D. In addition, Board Resolution 7051 directed the Superintendent to have the Office of School Modernization along with the three Design Advisory Groups at Jefferson High School, Cleveland High School and Ida B. Wells High School analyze and recommend cost reductions in the design and construction recommendations to reduce the cost of the high school modernizations and to use the cost savings for critical improvements, repairs and updates in the school district's elementary and middle.

E. In response to that resolution, district staff and the Design Advisory Groups have undertaken work to reduce the cost of the schools and in an April 7th Staff Memo to the Board said: The current combined estimated total project cost ranges from $1.348 billion to $1.380 billion. Of this, $406 million is funded through the 2020 General Obligation (GO) Bond. As a result, the remaining funding required for the projects is between $942 million and $974 million. The proposed 2025 GO Bond allocates $1.150 billion for modernization projects, **leaving a balance between $176 and $208 million for additional modernization initiatives."**

F. The Portland area faces a significant seismic threat from the Cascadia Subduction Zone – a major offshore fault capable of producing catastrophic earthquakes – and the Oregon Department of Emergency Management has estimated there is roughly a *37% chance* of a Cascadia megaquake occurring in the Pacific Northwest within the next 50 years.

G. Numerous PPS school buildings are of unreinforced masonry (URM) construction – the type of structure most prone to failure during strong shaking – and a recent

District seismic assessment identified certain schools as high-risk URM sites that pose a significant risk to students and staff who occupy them.

H. Structural engineering experts have warned that these URM school buildings are “definitely not safe for large earthquakes” and could even suffer catastrophic collapse in a moderate earthquake (not only during a “big one”), threatening the lives and safety of children and educators.

I. Many parents, staff, and community members have voiced deep concern about the seismic safety of our schools, underscoring that the community expects urgent action to seismically upgrade many District school buildings and to protect our children.

J. Over the past decade Portland voters have repeatedly supported school safety and modernization through bond measures in **2012, 2017, and 2020**, which authorized $482 million, $790 million, and $1.2 billion respectively for capital improvements; these bonds – along with additional support from the state’s Seismic Rehabilitation Grant Program – have funded the rebuilding or full seismic retrofit of several schools (including Franklin, Grant, and Roosevelt High Schools, and Alameda, Lewis, and Kellogg schools), significantly improving their earthquake resilience.

K. Bond-funded improvement projects in recent years have also included incremental seismic upgrades at schools districtwide (for example, repairing or replacing aging roofs and anchoring them with seismic bracing); however, such partial measures are not equivalent to full seismic reinforcement, so many PPS school buildings still require comprehensive seismic retrofitting.

L. Despite the progress made to date, dozens of PPS school facilities remain seismically deficient or rated “poor” in expected earthquake performance.

M. In May 2025 the Board is presenting District voters with a proposed $1.8 billion school bond measure – the largest in PPS history – to continue rebuilding and updating aging schools, which includes the planned modernization of ClevelandId and; Ida B Wells High Schools as well as the completion of Jefferson High School; and It provides capacity for additional health, safety, and maintenance projects: This bond, if approved, would offer an important opportunity to fund seismic upgrades at high-risk schools as part of the broader capital program.

N. PPS has already conducted a **comprehensive seismic re-assessment** in 2024 of all school buildings, and will have additional evaluations and cost estimates to bring structures up to current seismic code where needed. This data-driven assessment allows the District to identify and prioritize the most at-risk school facilities for retrofitting in an informed and transparent manner.

O. Clear criteria and planning for seismic retrofits are essential to ensure that limited resources address the highest-risk buildings first.

P. The Board is committed to open and transparent decision-making in addressing facility safety needs, and has emphasized publicly that tough trade-offs may be required (for example, potentially deferring other facility upgrades like HVAC improvements or sustainability goals in order to prioritize critical seismic work). Such decisions will continue to be discussed in public forums so the community can understand and contribute to the process.

Q. The Board further acknowledges that seismic safety is an equity issue: **every** student, regardless of zip code or background, deserves to attend a seismically safe school. Schools serving historically underserved communities must not be left at greater risk, and equity considerations will inform the prioritization and implementation of all seismic improvements so that all PPS students and staff enjoy equal protection from earthquake hazards.

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED that the Board of Education of Portland Public Schools hereby:

1. **Declares** that the identification, mitigation, and seismic retrofitting of high-risk school buildings is an urgent district priority and a fundamental part of the district's duty to provide a safe learning environment. The Board affirms its commitment to take necessary steps to protect the lives and well-being of students and staff by substantially improving the seismic safety of all school facilities.

2. **Directs** the Superintendent (or designee) to develop and present a comprehensive districtwide **Seismic Risk Reduction Plan**. This plan shall utilize the latest seismic assessment data to identify all school facilities in need of seismic strengthening and shall prioritize retrofit projects based on objective risk factors (such as building structural ratings, construction type, and student occupancy levels), as well as equity considerations (e.g. the needs of vulnerable populations). The plan will outline a multi-year schedule or sequence for retrofitting the identified high-risk buildings and include cost estimates and potential funding strategies for each phase. The Superintendent shall deliver this plan to the Board in a timely manner, and no later than September 1, 2025.

3. **Commits** to prioritizing seismic upgrades in the District's capital improvement strategy, including the current 2025 bond program. **If the 2025 bond measure is approved by voters**, $190 million in the bond is allocated for Physical Facility Improvements intended to address deferred maintenance, ongoing capital renewal and priority scope improvements; There has also been $176 - $208 million in funds identified as potentially been available due to cost saving from the high school modernizations, for a potential total of approximately $366-398 million. From the available funds, the Board directs that the District will allocate the necessary funds to initiate and complete seismic retrofits or rebuilds at the highest-priority sites identified in the Seismic Risk Reduction Plan in accordance with this allocation methodology:

a. PPS will first establish a reserve fund necessary for emergency, system end-of-useful life replacement and unplanned projects to respond to imminent or risks to students or PPS personnel, assumed to be in the range of $100 million over the life of the bond.

b. Beyond the funds needed for that reserve, there shall be a default presumption that the first and highest use of funds available to address critical repairs and improvements at middle and elementary schools is to mitigate the seismic deficiencies at the 8-10 schools assessed to pose the greatest risk of injury or death in a significant seismic event. PPS management may seek approval of the PPS School Board to deviate from the default presumption upon a written showing of impracticality, demonstrable need, or reasonable evidence that alternate expenditures of funds are necessary for the health and safety of PPS students and staff. If the District determines that any of the 8-10 schools assessed to pose the greatest risk should be replaced entirely, any plan to build new schools or consolidate existing schools will be determined by the District's closure and consolidation policy and process.

c. All remaining funds available for use to address critical repairs and improvements at middle and elementary schools shall be expended based on the District's critical repair prioritization.

4. Furthermore, the Board calls on future Boards to continue to prioritize seismic upgrades in **future capital bond measures** developed by PPS and shall continue to prioritize funding provisions to continue the work of seismic retrofitting until every high-risk school building in the district has been upgraded or replaced to meet modern seismic safety standards.

5. **Directs** the District to continue its aggressive pursuit of **state and federal funding** opportunities to support school seismic upgrades, in order to supplement local bond funds and accelerate the retrofitting program.

6. The Board also urges the District's administration to advocate for increased state and federal investment in school seismic safety, including any legislative efforts that would provide funding or mandates to improve the resiliency of public school buildings.

7. The Board directs the Superintendent (or designee) to ensure that the planning and implementation of seismic retrofit projects will be carried out with full **transparency** and an **equity-focused approach**, in partnership with the community. The District shall publicly share the findings of the seismic risk assessments and keep families, staff, and the broader community informed about upcoming seismic projects and their timelines.

8. The process for determining the sequence of school retrofits will be clearly communicated and based on the established criteria (risk level, urgency, equity impact, etc.), with opportunities for community input so that stakeholders' voices

are heard. The Board directs the Superintendent to provide regular progress reports, preferably quarterly, on the status of seismic improvements – including work completed, work in progress, funding used, and any adjustments to the schedule – at Board meetings open to the public. In doing so, the Board will support ongoing accountability, build public trust, and uphold our community-centered responsibility to make every Portland public school a safe place to learn and work.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that this resolution shall become effective immediately upon its adoption, and the Board of Education shall monitor and support its implementation to reaffirm that the safety of our students and staff remains the highest priority in Portland Public Schools.